

ANNEX R.A

Escalation Buffer Activation Protocol

*Automatic Triggers, Response Time Requirements, and
Facilitator Accountability for Real-Time Crisis Management*

Superseding Protocol to Annex R | Version 1.0

Self-Contained | Incorporable by Reference | Authorized Negotiators Only

CONFIDENTIAL — AUTHORIZED NEGOTIATORS ONLY

Table of Contents

Preamble

Article 1: Automatic Activation of 72-Hour Buffer

- 1.1 Trigger Events
- 1.2 Clock Start Mechanism
- 1.3 Dispute Over Trigger Existence

Article 2: Back-Channel Activation and Response Requirements

- 2.1 Simultaneous Facilitator Activation
- 2.2 Response Time Requirements
- 2.3 Designated Official Availability

Article 3: Facilitator Accountability and Fallback

- 3.1 Tiered Facilitator Fallback Chain
- 3.2 PCC Secretariat Emergency Protocol
- 3.3 Facilitator Suspension

Article 4: Rogue Actor and False-Flag Provisions

- 4.1 Operational Override Conditions
- 4.2 Failure to Disavow
- 4.3 Knowing Falsification
- 4.4 Good-Faith Correction

Article 5: Buffer Extension Without Mutual Agreement

- 5.1 PCC-Ordered Extension
- 5.2 Maximum Extension
- 5.3 Prohibited Actions During Extension

5.4 Buffer Deactivation

Article 6: Relationship to Annex R

Article 7: Incorporation by Reference

Article 8: Provisional Application

What Annex R.a Does That Annex R Did Not

Signature Block

Preamble

Annex R establishes the Escalation Buffer Period and back-channel de-confliction mechanism but does not specify the activation triggers, response time requirements, or facilitator accountability necessary for real-time crisis management in the hours following a kinetic incident.

This Annex R.a provides those operational mechanics. It does not amend Annex R. It activates it.

Three Questions Answered by Annex R.a

Question	Annex R	Annex R.a Resolution
Who pushes the button?	"Automatically activates" but no trigger list specified	5 specific trigger events; automatic; no PCC vote or facilitator approval required
How fast does the back-channel need to respond?	"Initial acknowledgment within 30 minutes" but no consequences defined	Complete response time table with acknowledgment, substantive response, and consequences for non-response for every communication type
What if a facilitator doesn't answer?	Not specified	Tiered fallback chain: Pakistan → Switzerland → Oman → PCC Secretariat

Modularity Clause

This Annex R.a is self-contained. The Parties incorporate it into any existing or future agreement through a single sentence of adoption. It does not amend or supersede conflicting provisions of any parent framework unless the Parties explicitly so agree. In the event of inconsistency, Annex R.a governs with respect to activation triggers, back-channel response requirements, facilitator accountability, rogue actor provisions, and buffer extension procedures.

Article 1: Automatic Activation of 72-Hour Buffer

OPERATIVE AND BINDING

1.1 Trigger Events

The 72-hour Escalation Buffer Period under Annex R, Article 4, activates automatically upon the occurrence of any of the following trigger events, without requiring PCC vote, Party request, or facilitator approval.

Trigger		Definition	Verification
Unidentified aerial incursion or projectile		Any unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) crossing the airspace boundary of either Party's territorial or declared exclusion zone, regardless of intent	Radar track logged by either Party or guarantor state; notification to PCC within 2 hours
Naval violation	stand-off	Any vessel operating under the authority of either Party entering the 5-nm stand-off perimeter defined in parent framework Article 6.3	AIS data; satellite imagery; or visual confirmation transmitted to PCC
Missile launch or intercept		Any ballistic or cruise missile launch, defensive intercept, or destruction event within 200 km of the Hormuz Transit Zone	Telemetry data; early warning system notification; guarantor state confirmation
Explosive event at declared facility		Any detonation, fire, or structural collapse at a declared nuclear facility or adjacent storage area	IAEA notification; Iranian facility report; satellite change detection
Civilian interdiction	vessel	Any attempt to halt, board, delay, or deny transit to a commercial vessel in the Hormuz Transit Zone under Annex N	Vessel operator report; AIS deviation; US naval observation

1.2 Clock Start Mechanism

The 72-hour clock begins at the earliest verifiable timestamp of the trigger event, as determined by:

1. Joint Secretariat time stamp if both Parties agree on the event time; or
2. The median of the three earliest independent verification sources (radar, satellite, signals intercept) if the Parties disagree.

1.3 Dispute Over Trigger Existence

Neither Party unilaterally declares that a trigger event did not occur for the purpose of preventing buffer activation. Any dispute over whether a trigger event occurred is resolved by the PCC within 12 hours, with the buffer remaining active during the dispute.

The presumption during any dispute is that the buffer is active. The burden of demonstrating that a trigger event did not occur lies with the Party asserting non-occurrence. The PCC reviews all available verification data and issues a binding determination within 12 hours.

Article 2: Back-Channel Activation and Response Requirements

OPERATIVE AND BINDING

2.1 Simultaneous Facilitator Activation

Upon automatic activation of the 72-hour buffer, the back-channel de-confliction mechanism under Annex R, Article 3, is immediately and simultaneously activated through all three facilitators (Pakistan, Switzerland, Oman) until acknowledgment is received from at least one.

Cross-reference: The three-tiered facilitator chain is detailed in Article 3. The primary facilitator is Pakistan; secondary is Switzerland; tertiary is Oman. If all three fail, the PCC Secretariat assumes temporary facilitation duties.

2.2 Response Time Requirements

The following response time requirements apply to all back-channel communications during the buffer period:

Communication Type	Acknowledgment	Substantive Response	Consequence of Non-Response
Tactical notification (incident report)	Within 30 minutes	Within 4 hours (initial assessment)	PCC automatically notified; incident presumptively classified as Strategic Breach if no response within 12 hours
Clarification of intent request	Within 30 minutes	Within 4 hours (factual explanation)	Other Party's preliminary classification given presumptive weight in PCC review
De-escalation proposal	Within 30 minutes	Within 4 hours (accept, reject, or counter)	Proposal deemed rejected; PCC imposes cooling-off extension
Stand-down confirmation	Within 30 minutes	Within 2 hours (with verification)	Stand-down not confirmed; buffer period extended 24 hours automatically

2.3 Designated Official Availability

The designated officials under Annex R, Article 3.2, are reachable 24/7 via secure channel. Each Party tests the back-channel connection weekly at a random time selected by the PCC.

Weekly Back-Channel Test Protocol

The PCC initiates a test communication to each Party's designated official at a random time once per week. The receiving Party acknowledges within 2 hours. Failure to respond to a test within 2 hours constitutes a Tier 1 technical violation. Three consecutive test failures in any 30-day period are referred to the PCC as a potential capacity issue requiring replacement of the designated official.

Article 3: Facilitator Accountability and Fallback

OPERATIVE AND BINDING

3.1 Tiered Facilitator Fallback Chain

Tier	Facilitator	Activation Condition	Responsibilities
Primary	Pakistan	Default; active upon buffer activation	Transmit all back-channel communications; maintain contemporaneous log; publish to Swiss Dashboard within 24 hours
Secondary	Switzerland	Primary fails to transmit within 30 minutes of receipt	Assume all primary responsibilities; notify PCC of primary failure; maintain parallel log
Tertiary	Oman	Both primary and secondary fail to transmit within 30 minutes	Assume all primary responsibilities; notify PCC of cascade failure; maintain parallel log
Emergency	PCC Secretariat	All three facilitators unresponsive for more than 2 hours during active buffer	Temporary facilitation via encrypted email to both Parties' designated officials; read receipts required within 1 hour

3.2 PCC Secretariat Emergency Protocol

If all three facilitators are unresponsive for more than 2 hours during an active buffer period, the PCC Secretariat assumes temporary facilitation duties and transmits all communications via encrypted email to both Parties' designated officials, with read receipts required within 1 hour.

Emergency Communication Requirements

1. All transmissions use the PCC Secretariat's authenticated encryption keys (HSM-protected, dual-key)
2. Read receipts are mandatory; absence of a read receipt within 1 hour triggers direct telephone contact via pre-designated crisis numbers
3. The PCC Secretariat maintains a complete contemporaneous log of all emergency communications
4. All three suspended facilitators are notified of the emergency assumption and are required to resume duties within 4 hours or face suspension review

3.3 Facilitator Suspension

A facilitator that fails to meet the response time requirements more than twice in any 90-day period is suspended from the back-channel roster pending a PCC review of its capacity to serve. The remaining facilitators cover its duties during suspension. The PCC review assesses: technical capacity of the facilitator's communication infrastructure; staffing adequacy for 24/7 coverage; and political willingness to continue serving. The facilitator is reinstated upon satisfactory resolution of all identified deficiencies.

Article 4: Rogue Actor and False-Flag Provisions

OPERATIVE AND BINDING

4.1 Operational Override Conditions

If a trigger event is caused by a rogue commander, unauthorized unit, or third-party false-flag operation, the event is not attributed to either Party for purposes of breach classification, provided the affected Party meets the following conditions within 24 hours of the event:

Req	Action	Standard
1	Public disavowal	Issued at the ministerial level or above; published through official government channels; transmitted to PCC and all guarantor states within 24 hours
2	Commitment to proceedings	Written commitment to disciplinary or legal proceedings against those responsible; proceedings commenced within 30 days; PCC receives monthly status reports
3	Joint investigation offer	Formal offer of joint investigation through the back-channel within 24 hours; investigation terms negotiated within 72 hours; findings published to Swiss Dashboard
4	PCC and guarantor notification	Simultaneous notification to PCC and all guarantor states within 6 hours of event; preliminary assessment within 24 hours; full report within 72 hours

4.2 Failure to Disavow

If a Party fails to issue a valid disavowal within 24 hours, the event is deemed adopted by that Party and is classifiable as a Strategic Breach under Annex R, Article 5. The PCC convenes an emergency session within 12 hours of the 24-hour deadline expiry. The presumption is that the Party authorized the event, and the burden of proving otherwise shifts to that Party.

4.3 Knowing Falsification

If a Party knowingly provides false information about a trigger event to the PCC, the back-channel, or guarantor states, that Party is subject to immediate Tier 3 breach procedures under the parent framework,

regardless of the buffer period status. The PCC determines knowing falsification by majority vote of non-Party members within 72 hours. Indicators of knowing falsification include: information contradicted by independent verification sources; pattern of inconsistent statements; refusal to provide access to relevant personnel or records; and destruction or concealment of evidence.

4.4 Good-Faith Correction

Good-faith correction of inaccurate preliminary information within 48 hours does not constitute a violation of this Article. Preliminary assessments provided in the immediate aftermath of a trigger event are understood to be incomplete. A Party that promptly corrects its initial assessment upon receipt of new information demonstrates transparency and is not penalized for the initial inaccuracy, provided the correction is made within 48 hours and no material deception is involved.

Article 5: Buffer Extension Without Mutual Agreement

OPERATIVE AND BINDING

5.1 PCC-Ordered Extension

If, at the end of the initial 72-hour buffer period, the PCC determines by majority vote of non-Party members that:

- Forensic assessment remains incomplete; or
- De-escalation proposals are under active consideration; or
- One Party is acting in good faith while the other is delaying;

the PCC extends the buffer period for a single additional 72-hour period without requiring mutual agreement of the Parties.

5.2 Maximum Extension

The PCC does not extend the buffer beyond 144 hours total without the written consent of both Parties. If consensus for further extension is not reached by the expiry of the 144-hour period, the buffer deactivates automatically and the standard dispute resolution mechanisms of the parent framework apply. Neither Party unilaterally vetoes deactivation once the 144-hour maximum is reached.

5.3 Prohibited Actions During Extension

During any PCC-ordered extension, all prohibited actions under Annex R, Article 4.2 remain in force. Specifically:

- No offensive military operations within the buffer zone
- No reinforcement of military positions in the Hormuz Transit Zone
- No issuance of public statements accusing the other Party of responsibility
- No unilateral sanctions adjustments
- No suspension of humanitarian channels

Violation of any prohibited action during extension is treated as a Tier 2 Material Disruption under the parent framework step-back/earn-back provisions.

5.4 Buffer Deactivation

The Escalation Buffer Period deactivates automatically upon the earliest of:

- (a)** 72 hours from activation (or 144 hours if extended under Article 5.1);
- (b)** PCC determination by majority vote of non-Party members that the incident is resolved and no further de-escalation is needed; or
- (c)** Mutual written agreement of both Parties transmitted through the back-channel.

PCC Early Deactivation Procedure

Either Party requests early deactivation at any time during the buffer period by transmitting a formal request through the back-channel. The PCC convenes within 4 hours of the request and votes on deactivation. If the PCC determines by majority vote of non-Party members that the trigger event has been satisfactorily resolved, the buffer deactivates immediately upon written notification to both Parties. If the PCC declines early deactivation, the buffer continues for the remainder of its active period unless extended.

Post-Deactivation Procedures

Upon deactivation, the PCC publishes a deactivation bulletin to the Swiss Dashboard within 6 hours, including: a summary of the trigger event; actions taken during the buffer period; any outstanding issues requiring follow-up; and confirmation that all prohibited actions under Article 5.3 are no longer in force. Neither Party unilaterally reactivates the buffer without a new trigger event under Article 1.1.

Article 6: Relationship to Annex R

OPERATIVE AND BINDING

6.1 This Annex R.a is a superseding operational protocol to Annex R. It does not amend Annex R's text but provides the activation, response, and accountability mechanics that Annex R assumes.

6.2 In the event of any inconsistency between Annex R and Annex R.a, Annex R.a governs with respect to: (a) activation triggers for the Escalation Buffer Period; (b) response time requirements for back-channel communications; (c) facilitator accountability and fallback procedures; (d) rogue actor and false-flag attribution rules; and (e) buffer extension without mutual agreement.

6.3 All other provisions of Annex R remain in full force and effect. Annex R.a is designed to operate as an activation layer that makes Annex R functional in real-time crisis conditions. Neither Annex supersedes the other in its entirety.

Cross-reference: Annex R.a is optimized for use with Annex R but provides stand-alone activation protocols for any framework with an escalation buffer mechanism. Both Annexes are designed to operate as a unified system, and incorporation of both is recommended for full operational functionality.

Article 7: Incorporation by Reference

OPERATIVE AND BINDING

This Annex R.a is incorporable into any existing or future agreement through the following adoption sentence:

"The Parties adopt Annex R.a (Escalation Buffer Activation Protocol) as a superseding operational protocol to Annex R. In the event of any inconsistency, Annex R.a governs with respect to activation triggers, back-channel response requirements, facilitator accountability, rogue actor provisions, and buffer extension procedures."

No amendment of Annex R or any parent framework is needed. This Annex R.a enters into force upon signature by both Parties or upon provisional application by exchange of diplomatic notes.

Article 8: Provisional Application

OPERATIVE AND BINDING

The Parties apply this Annex R.a provisionally for 90 days, pending formal incorporation. Provisional application is effected by an exchange of diplomatic notes. During provisional application, all provisions of this Annex R.a are operative and binding.

Either Party terminates provisional application with 14 days' written notice.

Note: Termination of provisional application does not affect incidents that occurred during provisional application; those remain governed by Annex R.a. The 14-day notice period allows for orderly transition without leaving active incidents ungoverned.

What Annex R.a Does That Annex R Did Not

Issue	Annex R	Annex R.a
Who activates the buffer?	Unclear — "automatically activates" but no trigger list defined	5 specific trigger events; automatic; no vote required
How fast does the back-channel need to respond?	"Initial acknowledgment within 30 minutes" but no consequences defined	Complete table: acknowledgment, substantive response, and consequences for every communication type
What if facilitator doesn't answer?	Not specified	Tiered fallback: Pakistan → Switzerland → Oman → PCC Secretariat
Rogue actor / false flag operational timeline	Mentioned but no 24-hour timeline	24-hour disavowal requirement; 4 specific conditions; otherwise event deemed adopted
Buffer extension without mutual agreement	Not permitted	PCC extends 72 more hours by majority vote of non-Party members; 144-hour hard cap
Testing the back-channel	Not specified	Weekly random test; failure to respond within 2 hours = Tier 1 violation
Clock start dispute	Not addressed	Median of three earliest verification sources; 12-hour PCC resolution; buffer active during dispute
Knowing falsification	Not addressed	Immediate Tier 3; PCC determines by majority vote of non-Party members within 72 hours; good-faith correction within 48 hours exempted

Signature Block

In witness whereof, the undersigned, being duly authorized by their respective governments, have signed this Annex R.a: Escalation Buffer Activation Protocol.

Done at _____, this _____ day of _____, 2026, in triplicate in the English language.

For the Islamic Republic of Iran:

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date: _____

For the United States of America:

Name: _____

Title: _____

Date: _____

Witnessed by the Joint Secretariat (Muscat):

Signature: _____

Date: _____

Annex R.a

Escalation Buffer Activation Protocol

Superseding Protocol to Annex R | Version 1.0

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